

Different Aspect Ratios

3:2 - 35mm film, DSLR camera, Smartphones

4:3 - SDTV/Video, computer displays

5:4 - Computer displays

16:9 - HDTV, Widescreen, SDTV, smartphones (Horizontal)

1.85:1 - Cinema film (US)

16:10 - Widescreen computer displays, smartphones (Horizontal)

2.35:1 - Cinemascope

9:16 - Smartphones (Vertical)

Defining a look

- The director can take months to form mental image
- Art directors job needs to embrace directors ideas & translate onto screen
- Need to create a unifying colour palette
- Create a common artistic ground; words are inadequate (mood lighting = different connotation to different people)

CONTRAST

- Emphasises message
- Film narrative works in binary
oppositions: good/evil, heaven/hell, black/white,
hero/villain = works to heighten
the sense of polarity

TRANSFORMATIONS

- When alone: cold colour, clinical, metallic blues, aluminium, metal, chrome
- When in relationship; warmth reds and greens, plush textures.
- Reflects narrative, or character development

THE NARRATIVE

- Inspiration from themes, characters and stories
- Cinematography: scale of space vs onscreen
- space = spatial influence

THE CHARACTERS

- The environment can communicate useful details
- Personality is suggested through space, light, colour and dressing

GEOGRAPHY OF SPACE MAPPING

- Space and movement
- How rooms link together = pattern of repetition if space is used repeatedly.
- Splitting between onset & studio filming, still needs to be seamless

GEOGRAPHY OF SPACE DIVISION & LAYERS

- Divided in foreground vertically or horizontally e.g. Paddington (2014)

No need to conform to conventions

GEOGRAPHY OF SPACE HEIGHT

- Ceiling often unseen in film & TV
 - Flexibility for shooting angles, lighting & mechanics
 - Spatial distance represented through head height
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- Conceptualisation
 - Recreations

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Set Design Definition

- Creation of physical spaces that support the film's story.
- Goes beyond walls and furniture to create atmosphere.
- Communicates tone, mood, and context of a scene.

Early Cinema (1890s-1930s)

Set design inspired by theater, with painted backdrops and props.

Example:

A Trip to the Moon (1902), using hand-painted sets for fantasy landscapes.

Golden Age of Hollywood (1930s-1950s)

Large-scale, elaborate sets for visual spectacle.

Example:

Gone with the Wind, Singin' in the Rain - grandeur and romantic detail.

Modernist and Realist Influences (1960s-1980s)

Desire for realism in set design, reflecting real-world environments.

Example:

Taxi Driver - gritty urban settings that feel like characters themselves.

Contemporary Trends (1990s-Present)

Mixed reality with CGI and practical sets.

Example:

Avatar (fantastical CGI worlds) and Parasite (realistic sets symbolizing class struggle).

Design Process of Film Sets

Step 1: Script Analysis

- Analyze the script to understand mood, themes, and characters.

Example: For a horror film, sets might be darker, confined, and unsettling.

Step 2: Concept Development

- Brainstorm ideas, create mood boards, collect reference images, and sketch initial ideas.
- Focus on the overall aesthetic and how to communicate the film's tone.

Step 3: Set Planning and Design

- Create technical drawings, models, and digital renderings.
- Use 3D modeling software like Rhino to visualize the set's scale and layout.

Step 4: Set Construction and Dressing

- Build the set according to plans, then dress it with furniture, props, and textures to create a lived-in feel.

Step 5: Collaboration with Other Departments Work with the director, cinematographer, and lighting designers to ensure the set aligns with the film's visual needs.

- Lighting can significantly affect the set's atmosphere.

Step 6: On-Set Adjustments

- Make adjustments during shooting for camera angles

Examples

Case Studies: Iconic Film Sets

Fantasy Example: The Lord of the Rings

- Sets like Rivendell and Hobbiton blend natural landscapes with fantasy architecture.
- Set designers had to make Middle Earth feel authentic by merging real-world elements with detailed fantasy environment.

Case Studies: Iconic Film Sets

Realism Example: Parasite

- The house is designed to reflect the film's themes, contrasting the sleek upper-class home with the cramped basement apartment.
- This visual metaphor enhances the narrative's depth.

Case Studies: Iconic Film Sets

Experimental Example: Inception

- Set design plays with architectural principles to create dream-like spaces.
- Designers used physical models and digital effects for sets that defy reality, such as the folding city and the rotating hallway fight scene.

Enter and Exit

First impressions mean everything! It will impact our sense of character and story.

Doors:

In domestic settings, doorways are often the portal between different ideas in film.

Corridors

- To extend physically and prolong visually the transition of space
- Called 'LIMINAL' as a space of journey, an in between of more meaningful spaces as they often act as punctuation
- They can create suspension = waiting for the 'stop' in a room for the story to continue

Staircases and Lifts

Similar function to corridors and passageways

- Useful as a metaphor for the rise and fall in character arc (similar to doors, material, size, shape...)

RESOLUTION

For TV sets

- TV sets use camera movements and transitions of space to replicate well establish cinematic techniques to add visual value
 - Without well establish film techniques, TV sets and filming would become rather boring
- Set design provides space for 'Holographics'

Post-site visit information:

The 3 distinct looks' should be classified as the following:

- Morning show
- Intellectual show (think QI)
- Late night show we're thinking neon/fluorescent vibe)

Still use the characteristics we discussed in class to describe the spaces for design development, submission & for the competition.

This will hopefully give the three looks some more direction to finish off the aesthetics.

STORYBOARD

Definition:

A sequence of drawings representing the shots planned for a film or video production.

Purpose in Filmmaking:

Storyboards communicate visual ideas, sequences, camera angles, and the mood of the scenes.

Relevance to Architecture:

Visual Communication: Like architectural drawings, storyboards communicate ideas visually before they are built or filmed.

Spatial Planning: Storyboarding involves organizing and designing spaces for characters, similar to how architects design spaces for people.

Perspective: Both disciplines require the use of perspective drawing to create a sense of depth and spatial understanding.

Key Elements of a Storyboard

Framing & Composition:

How each shot is composed, deciding what to include or leave out, and the camera's angle and distance.

Similar to selecting the viewpoint for an architectural drawing or render.

Example: Wide shots provide an overview, while close-ups capture details—just like choosing an elevation view to show a building's façade or a detailed section for materials.

Lighting and Mood:

Sets mood, highlights areas, and influences emotional response.

Lighting shapes how a space is perceived and used similar to Architecture

Example: Bright lighting can make a space feel open and inviting; dim lighting adds intimacy or drama.

Movement & Flow:

Movement in storyboarding shows how characters or objects move, guiding the viewer's attention across the frame.

In architecture, movement translates to how users navigate through a space.

Example: Storyboard sequences create flow, while architects design corridors and doorways to direct movement.

Storyboarding as a Design Tool

Narrative in Architecture

Architects often create a "story" or narrative to guide their design choices.

Example: Designing a residential space where the narrative might focus on a journey from public to private areas.

In storyboarding, narrative is visually represented in each scene, helping viewers understand the story's flow and context.

User Experience:

Storyboards map out how characters move through a scene similar to tracking user movement in architectural spaces.

Architects use similar techniques to design the flow of movement and the experience of spaces.

Example: Storyboarding a gallery layout to envision how visitors will engage with the art displays and navigate the space.

Architectural Applications:

Many architects incorporate story-board-like techniques to plan spatial sequences and user interactions.

Example: Architect Rem Koolhaas uses cinematic techniques to explore narrative-driven spaces, while Bjarke Ingels uses diagrams and sketches as storyboards to communicate spatial experiences.

Interior architects can use storyboards to visualize how people will interact with spaces in a sequence, making it easier to plan user-friendly layouts.

Storyboards as a Presentation Tool

Visualizing Ideas for Clients:

Storyboards effectively present design concepts to clients, similar to how directors communicate with production teams.

They visually convey spatial experiences and user interactions, bridging the gap between the designer's vision and the client's understanding.

Collaboration Across Disciplines:

Storyboards facilitate collaboration with other professionals, such as lighting designers, interior designers, and sound engineers.

They provide a visual sense of the intended experience, promoting an interdisciplinary approach. This collaboration is essential in complex projects where multiple elements must work together seamlessly.

Step Guide to Making a Story-board:

- Choose Your Story
- Identify Key Frames
- Sketch the Frames
- Add Descriptions
- Consider Composition

- Refine Your Storyboard
- Finalize Your Storyboard

Conclusion & Key Takeaways

- Storyboarding is a powerful visual tool for architects.
- Enhances communication of design concepts to clients.
- Aids in spatial design, lighting, and narrative flow.
- Encourages interdisciplinary collaboration.
- Integrating storyboarding into workflows improves design presentations.

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Ambient

Blankets a space and provides the base or minimum level of illumination. It is important when establishing an impression or creating a mood. It is the general light in a space.

Task

Provides additional light in areas that require visual tasks. E.g. desktop or office cubical. Circulation space around the task lighting would be ambient.

Accent

Provides a visual interest highlighting the architecture or calling attention to important elements. It is a directional light used to emphasise or draw attention to an object.

Sources and Position

- A lack of highlighting = dull flat effect
- Shade suggestive of notions of safety, conformity, boredom or inertia
- Use of daylighting Illogical to use when you need to control the environment/for editing purposes

3 POINT LIGHTING

Back Light/Hair Light

- lights an actor or object from behind
- placed higher than the object it is lighting
- separates the actor or object from the background
- when placed at an angle it's called a "kicker"

Fill light

- cancels out the shadows created by the key light, doesn't create it's own shadows
- less powerful than the key light
- placed opposite the key light

Key Light

- primary light source of the scene
- the most intense and direct light source
- illuminates the subject or actor

Atmosphere, time, place, character and even plot development.

Aggressive - warm

The yellows, oranges and reds.

- Towards the eye spatially
- Louder than passive colours

Passive - cool

The greens, blues and violets.

- Recede from the eye

- Quieter than aggressive colours.

Soft/diffuse light allows textures and tones to have more visibility

Richard Kelly's Three Forms of Lightplay

- Ambient luminescence, focal glow and play of brilliants

A gobo = stencil or template put inside or in front of a light source.

Cucolorises (cookie) used to shape and direct light in a specific way - further away from light source.

What is On-Set Design?

Physical spaces where scenes are filmed.
Must be functional for actors, cameras, and crew.
Includes: Fixed sets, modular elements, and open spaces for filming flexibility.

Key Features of On-Set Design

Layout: Optimized for camera angles and actor movement.
Modularity: Reconfigurable for multiple scenes.
Integration: Accommodates lighting, sound, and camera rigs seamlessly.

What is Set Decoration?

Purpose: Enhances the storyline by creating immersive environments.
Components: Props, furniture, colors, textures, and accessories.
Collaboration with production designers and art directors.

Key Considerations

Era and location: Does the set match the story's time period and setting?
Character-driven spaces: Reflect the psychology and lifestyle of characters.

Aspect	On-Set Design	Set Decoration
Definition	Focuses on creating the physical structure and layout of the set.	Involves adding details, furniture, and decor to enhance realism and mood.
Purpose	Provides the framework and spatial context for filming.	Fills the framework with items that support storytelling and character development.
Scope	Walls, floors, architectural elements, lighting rigs, and functional components.	Furniture, props, textiles, artwork, and other decorative items.
Timing in Process	Done during the early stages of set construction	Happens after the structural set is built and ready for dressing.
Collaboration	Works dosely with the	Collaborates with the

	director and cinematographer to align the set layout with the visual narrative.	production designer, prop master, and art director to align decorations with the film's aesthetic.
Roles Involved	Production Designer, Art Director, Construction Crew.	Set Decorator, Prop Master, and Art Department.
Technical Needs	Considers camera angles, actor movement, and technical aspects like lighting and rigging.	Ensures items are functional and visually consistent with the story's era, location, and characters.
Creativity	Focuses on structural and spatial innovation.	Prioritizes storytelling through aesthetic and cultural detail.
Examples	Building a Victorian mansion's façade and rooms.	Adding period-accurate furniture, drapery, and paintings to the mansion.

Creating Realistic Yet Functional Spaces

Balance Between Realism and Feasibility:
Sets must look authentic on-screen while accommodating production needs like camera movements and lighting rigs. For example, a castle might appear vast and medieval but is often built as modular pieces in a soundstage.

Use of Forced Perspective:
This technique manipulates visual perception to make sets appear larger or more dynamic. Examples include shrinking props as they move further back or angling walls to suggest depth, as seen in The Lord of the Rings.

Material Substitution:
Materials like foam or lightweight plastics mimic heavy stone or metal to create visually convincing yet portable and safe environments.

Designing for Cinematic Techniques

Lighting and Shadow Play:
The set must interact harmoniously with the lighting plan to support mood and tone. For instance, shadows on jagged walls might suggest tension, while soft, warm lighting in a cozy room conveys com-fort.

Accommodating Camera Angles:

Sets are designed with cinematography in mind, allowing for close-ups, wide shots, and tracking movements. This requires thoughtful spatial organization and "wild walls" (removable panels) for camera access.

Evoking Emotion and Storytelling

Visual Language:

Every design choice communicates something about the narrative or characters. For example, a chaotic, cluttered room might reflect a disorganized or troubled character.

World-Building Through Detail:

Designers build immersive environments that feel lived-in. In *Blade Runner 2049*, neon lights, decayed buildings, and dense urban layers combine to create a believable dystopia.

Period and Genre-Specific Styles:

Sets often reflect specific historical eras or fantasy genres. Research into architectural and cultural history ensures that design choices resonate authentically.

Illusion Through Technology

Green Screen Integration:

Partial sets are combined with digital environments to create expansive worlds. For instance, in *The Mandalorian*, LED screens project digital back-drops, blending real and virtual elements seamlessly.

Miniatures and Models:

These are used for establishing shots or complex sequences. For example, the cityscapes in *Inception* used scale models enhanced with CGI to create surreal, dreamlike visuals.

Flexibility and Modularity

Transformable Sets:

Sets are often designed to serve multiple scenes. A single street might be redressed to appear as various locations, saving time and budget.

Hidden Practicalities:

While a set looks complete on film, the reverse side often includes scaffolding, wiring, or access spaces for crew and equipment.

Health and safety

Structural Integrity

Sets must be strong and stable, especially large or complex ones. Designers must make sure

everything is securely attached and able to hold the weight of actors, props, and equipment. For heavy props or high structures like platforms and lights, calculations are needed to ensure safety. Weakly secured pieces can cause accidents.

Fire Safety

Use fireproof materials on set, especially if there are special effects or fireworks. Fire exits must be clearly marked, and fire extinguishers should always be nearby. All crew members should know what to do in case of an emergency.

Electrical Safety

Electrical wiring and equipment should be set up properly to avoid fires or electric shocks. Cables should be secured to prevent tripping, and all equipment should be properly grounded. Only qualified people should handle electrical tasks.

Tripping Hazards

The floor must be stable, and there should be no uneven surfaces or loose cables that could cause people to trip. Designers should create clear pathways for people and equipment to move safely.

Handling Special Effects

Special effects like smoke or explosions require careful planning. Professionals should manage any risky effects, and safety equipment must be on hand.

Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)

Crew members working with heavy equipment or dangerous materials should wear protective gear like helmets, gloves, and steel-toe boots. In some environments (e.g., loud or dusty areas, extra protection like earplugs or masks might be necessary.

Conclusion

- On-Set Design: Functional and flexible layouts.
- Set Decoration: Story-driven design.
- Architect of Illusion: Techniques for creating believable worlds.
- Health and Safety: A foundational priority.